

ment, marketing and sales. Professionals who have a superior understanding of electronics, instrumentation, electrical, mechanical and power engineering are required amongst others.

Most of the companies have ambitious expansion as well as diversification plans. Companies like NTPC have taken a number of steps to emerge as an integrated power company with presence in coal mining, hydel power generation, power trading and power distribution. Accordingly, there are huge job opportunities for new entrants.

While there is still a shortage of quality manpower in the power sector, this seems to be easing out with changing preferences among the fresh engineers from IT to core fields like power and other heavy industries. "We do find that entry-level technical graduates are still charmed by the IT industry, however this trend is changing and bright youngsters are choosing careers in the power industry looking at the long-term growth perspective," says Anil Kumar Challyil, technical services manager, Arrow Electronics.

As an electronics professional you may find your place in the power circuit design section of a solutions providing firm. But opportunities are present even in the maintenance, instrumentation and control sections of any power plant. Work opportunities in the power sector primarily include creation, expansion and enlarging of existing units by utilising both renewable and non-renewable energy sources. Upgradation of the existing capacity through modernisation of equipment and introduction of new technolo-

"In the times of an economic slowdown, the government looks to pump in more with respect to public expenditure, thus ensuring continuous job creation. For this reason, the power sector has the greatest element of anti-cyclical behaviour, thereby maintaining a healthy growth rate."

—Sunil Bhatnagar, director, Parker Power System



gies and better instrumentation may finally open up new job opportunities. Adjunct systems operating with core infrastructure, such as smart energy management systems for commercial and industrial units, may be a right choice for your career.

You may ask "How to get an entry ticket?" A decent technical background (ITI, diploma or graduation) along with fundamental knowledge can secure your job ticket. However, for some fields requiring specialised knowledge such as R&D, recruiters look for postgraduates and doctorates. Many employers take campus recruits and train them directly in different areas of power projects to prepare them for various roles in the company. Thankfully, most of the big players in this sector still believe in talent building rather than raiding. This was further confirmed by Neelam Kumar, executive director and head of the department-power electronics, Aplab, who considers talent building as a part of

social responsibility.

Power in your pocket

Let's check whether this field is powerful enough to fill your pocket to a good extent. You could be part of a major project as a junior engineer and grow in 10-12 years' time to head major projects. Speaking of salary prospects, fresh engineering graduates usually start at Rs 200,000-Rs 350,000 per annum and can grow into either generalist or specialist roles. However, the scene is a little daunting for diploma holders as their starting salary range is usually Rs 150,000 to 200,000 per annum.

Even at this moment of economic downturn, the power sector is offering salaries in the range of Rs 500,000 to Rs 1 million per annum for professionals with 5-7 years of experience. It should, however, be noted that for design-related roles, the salary is usually closer to the upper limit. Nonetheless, if you grab an international opportunity, the minimum salary may move up to around Rs 2 million within five years.

Explore the power circuit

I believe, up to this point, you have got enough boosters from the opportunities-to-be-grabbed in the power field. So get ready now to explore the power circuit. The power field is specifically suitable for engineering professionals with multidisciplinary interests, such as magnetics and mechanics. Exciting and technically satisfying careers can

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